

A FRAMEWORK IN CHAPTERS

Chapter Eight

Productivism

Compulsory productivity · the system that ranks productive activity above all being

Productivism is the system that ranks productive activity above all other forms of human being, enforces work as the condition of social standing, and extracts labour, time, and bodily capacity. This chapter runs it through the five domains — from the NYSC camp to the LinkedIn profile to the slow death of the worker whose body breaks down at thirty-five.

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CHAPTER 8 OF AN ONGOING FRAMEWORK

Productivism

Productivism is the seventh Fundamental Matrix. It ranks productive activity above all other forms of human being, enforces work as the condition of social standing, and extracts labour, time, and bodily capacity from everyone it can reach. The framework treats it as compulsory productivity — the demand that one be productive at all times, regardless of what is being produced.

Productivism overlaps with Enclosure (Chapter 7) at the wage relationship and with Rankism (Chapter 2) at workplace hierarchy. But the three matrices are not the same. Enclosure privatises access to resources required for living. Rankism ranks by position. Productivism ranks by productivity itself. The framework separates them so that each logic can be studied and dismantled on its own terms.

Productivism is a constituent of the Capitalism intersection (the Intersectional Matrices chapter combines Enclosure + Productivism + Rankism + State Sovereignty). This chapter studies Productivism on its own terms. The intersection returns when those four constituents are read together — Productivism supplies the ‘work’ infrastructure that the others depend on.

A note on method. The Interpersonal, Disciplinary, and Structural sections take the naive approach — each triad described as if happening for the first time, with no networks, residues, or Canon referenced. The Hegemonic Domain section is where Canon and Practice finally enter the picture.

READING NOTE

Same convention as Chapters 1 through 7. Every paragraph is written to be tweetable. Where you see literal blanks (____), the framework is asking you to write yourself into it. The blanks are the difference between reading about Productivism and locating yourself inside it.

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SECTION 1

1. Definition: What Productivism Extracts, Enforces, and Removes

Productivism is the system that ranks productive activity above all other forms of human being and enforces work as the condition of social standing. The term draws on Kathi Weeks's *The Problem with Work* (2011), which argued that the left's traditional defence of work had obscured the ways work itself produces domination. Weeks drew on the anti-work tradition of Marx, Gorz, and the wages-for-housework campaign.

Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) supplies the analytical distinction between labour (the reproductive activity necessary for survival), work (the fabrication of durable objects), and action (political activity among equals). Productivism collapses all three into labour, then elevates labour above action. The subject is reduced to labourer; the citizen is reduced to worker.

Max Weber's *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* (1905) traced the theological origin of Productivism to the Calvinist doctrine that worldly success is a sign of divine election. The Pentecostal prosperity gospel, which arrived in Nigeria from American televangelism in the 1970s and 1980s, is a direct descendant. Wealth is a sign of divine favour; poverty is a sign of spiritual failure; the unemployed are not only economically marginalised but spiritually suspect.

Byung-Chul Han's *The Burnout Society* (2010) and Jonathan Crary's *24/7* (2013) updated the analysis for the digital age. Han argues that the disciplinary society of the 20th century has been replaced by the achievement society, in which the subject self-exploits — the worker no longer needs an overseer because the worker has internalised the demand to achieve. Crary shows how the 24/7 market has colonised sleep, rest, and the night. Both arguments apply directly to the Lagos hustle culture of the 2010s and 2020s.

1.1 What Productivism Extracts

Productivism extracts six things. First, **wage-labour surplus**: the difference between what the worker produces and what the worker is paid. This triad overlaps with Enclosure (Chapter 7) at the wage relationship, but Productivism supplies the standard that the labour must be performed in the first place.

Second, **time**: the hours, days, and years the subject spends in productive activity. The 40-hour week is the formal minimum; the 60-hour week is the practical norm in Lagos professional culture; the 80-hour week is the badge of honour in finance and tech. Third, **attention**: the cognitive resource the subject directs at productive tasks. Attention is finite; Productivism extracts all of it.

Fourth, **reproductive labour**: the unpaid physical and emotional work of maintaining the worker — cooking, cleaning, childcare — that allows the worker to return to wage labour each day. Federici's wages-for-housework campaign showed that this labour is extracted from women to subsidise the wage-labour system. Fifth, **emotional labour**: the affective performance the worker performs for customers, colleagues, and supervisors.

Sixth, **cognitive labour**: the immaterial work of thinking, planning, designing, and coordinating that Lazzarato called 'immaterial labour' and Hardt and Negri called 'biopolitical production.' The cognitive worker brings their whole mind to work, and the boundary between work and life dissolves.

Seventh (a bonus), **self-improvement labour**: the work the subject performs on themselves to remain employable — the certification, the course, the LinkedIn post, the personal brand.

1.2 What Productivism Enforces

Productivism enforces five standards. First, the **employment relationship as the only route to social standing**: the subject who is not employed is deviant. The unemployed subject is pitied, suspected, or shamed. The retired subject is marginalised. The self-employed subject is judged by the visibility of their income.

Second, the **40-hour week**: the formal minimum of wage labour, codified in Nigerian labour law. The subject who works less is 'part-time' or 'casual.' The subject who works more is 'dedicated.' Third, the **9-to-5 schedule**: the temporal frame of Productivism, with the commute imposed around it. Fourth, the **CV / LinkedIn profile**: the document of productivity, in which the subject's life is reduced to a list of achievements.

Fifth, the **'what do you do?' question**: the introductory question that places the subject in the productivist hierarchy within the first minute of meeting. The subject who answers 'I am between jobs' is marked. The subject who answers 'I am a mother' is marked. The subject who answers 'I am resting' is incomprehensible. Sub-standards include the prohibition on rest without justification, the requirement of busyness as social currency, and the punishment of perceived idleness.

1.3 What Options Productivism Removes

Concretely, Productivism removes the option of refusing work. The subject who refuses employment is treated as deviant. The Lagos 28-year-old who would rather read than hustle is 'wasting their life.' The Abuja 35-year-old who has saved enough to live without wages is 'unambitious.' The 45-year-old who wants to slow down is 'past it.'

It removes the option of refusing the commute. The Lagos worker who would rather live near work and walk is priced out of the neighbourhoods near work. The worker who would rather work from home is 'not dedicated' until the pandemic briefly legitimised it. It removes the option of refusing the CV. The subject who would rather present themselves as a person than as a list of achievements is 'unprofessional.'

It removes the option of refusing the ‘what do you do?’ question. The subject who declines to answer is ‘rude’ or ‘evasive.’ It removes the option of being productive in ways that are not monetised. The artist who is not selling is ‘a hobbyist.’ The parent who is not earning is ‘not working.’ The volunteer is ‘wasting their time.’

It removes the right to rest without justification. The subject who rests is required to produce a medical reason, a family reason, or a religious reason. The subject who rests without justification is ‘lazy.’ It removes the right to idleness — the right to do nothing, to be nobody, to exist without producing. It removes the right to play, the right to contemplation, the right to non-economic activity. Each removal is enforced by family, by the employer, by the state, and by the triads below.

SECTION 2 · NAIVE APPROACH

2. The Interpersonal Domain

The Interpersonal Domain contains five enforcement triads and five extraction triads. Each is described here as if happening for the first time — no networks, no residues, no Canon. Just the act, the conforming subject, the complicit witness, and (for extraction triads) the Non-Extracting Beneficiary.

3.1 Enforcement Triad: Employment Relationship Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands the subject be employed. The parent who demands the adult child ‘get a job.’ The elder who demands the younger relative ‘be useful.’ The state that demands the citizen prove employment for benefits. The stranger who asks ‘what do you do?’ The enforcement is performed by direct demand, by moral judgment, by social exclusion, or by withholding benefits.

The subject conforms by being employed, by hiding their unemployment, or by performing busyness. The conforming act is the employment itself — the subject becomes ‘an engineer,’ ‘a teacher,’ ‘a banker’ on the form, in the introduction, in the social performance.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The unemployed subject loses the option to social standing, which is to say, loses the option to community. The employed subject who would rather rest loses the option to rest, which is to say, loses the option to bodily recovery. The self-employed subject who is not visibly earning loses the option to respect, which is to say, loses the option to be addressed as an equal.

The witness is the person who hears the employment demand and says nothing, or who themselves model compliance by being employed. The witness’s complicity normalises the demand. The employed witness who asks the unemployed ‘still looking?’ is closing the loop.

3.2 Enforcement Triad: Time Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands the subject’s time. The employer who demands the 60-hour week. The client who demands the immediate response. The supervisor who demands the Saturday work. The family member who demands the always-on availability. The enforcement is performed by direct demand, by tracking hours, by publicly noting those who leave on time, or by punishing those who do not give enough time.

The subject conforms by giving the time. The conforming act is the time itself — the hours, days, and years spent in productive activity. The time given is the proof of the system. The subject who does not give enough time is ‘not dedicated.’

The options the subject loses are concrete. The worker who gives 60 hours a week loses the option to rest, which is to say, loses the option to bodily recovery. The worker who gives the weekend loses the

option to family, which is to say, loses the option to relationships outside work. The worker who gives the night loses the option to sleep, which is to say, loses the option to cognitive function the next day.

The witness is the person who watches the time extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves give the time and so model compliance. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the family member who consumes the worker's wage — the spouse who does not work, the child who is in school — without personally commanding the time.

3.3 Enforcement Triad: 9-to-5 Schedule Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands the subject keep the 9-to-5 schedule. The employer who demands the 9am arrival. The supervisor who notes the 9:05am entrance. The HR officer who tracks the late marks. The culture that punishes the worker who arrives at 10am regardless of when they worked until. The enforcement is performed by the clock, by the time-sheet, by the late mark, by the public noting of arrival.

The subject conforms by arriving on time. The conforming act is the body's arrival — the worker is at the desk at 9am, regardless of when they left the night before. The arrival is the proof of the system. The worker who arrives at 9:05am is 'late,' even if they worked until 11pm the night before.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The worker who is a night person loses the option to work when they are most productive, which is to say, loses the option to cognitive alignment with their own body. The worker who lives far from work loses the option to sleep, because the commute demands the 5am wake. The worker who would rather work four 10-hour days than five 8-hour days loses the option to a schedule that suits them.

The witness is the person who watches the schedule enforcement and says nothing, or who themselves arrive on time and so model compliance. The witness's complicity is the shared acceptance that the 9-to-5 is the natural shape of the day.

3.4 Enforcement Triad: CV / LinkedIn Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands the subject present themselves as a list of achievements. The recruiter who demands the CV. The LinkedIn connection who demands the profile. The interviewer who demands the achievement narrative. The family member who demands the 'what have you achieved?' answer. The enforcement is performed by demanding the document, by judging the document, or by excluding those without the right document.

The subject conforms by producing the CV, by maintaining the LinkedIn, by narrating the achievements. The conforming act is the document itself — the subject's life is reduced to a list of productive outputs. The document is the proof of the system. The subject without the document is invisible.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The subject who would rather present themselves as a person loses the option to a non-productivist introduction, which is to say, loses the option to a self

that is not reduced to productivity. The subject who would rather not narrate their achievements loses the option to privacy. The subject whose achievements are not visible loses the option to employment, because the CV is the gate.

The witness is the person who watches the CV/LinkedIn enforcement and says nothing, or who themselves maintain the document and so model compliance. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the family member whose status rises because the subject's CV is impressive — the parent whose child is at a multinational — without personally commanding the CV.

3.5 Enforcement Triad: Justified Rest Standard

The enforcer is the person who demands the subject justify their rest. The employer who demands the medical certificate for sick leave. The supervisor who demands the family reason for personal leave. The culture that punishes the subject who rests without a documented reason. The enforcement is performed by demanding the justification, by withholding approval, or by punishing those who rest without permission.

The subject conforms by justifying. The conforming act is the justification itself — the medical certificate, the family reason, the religious reason. The justification is the proof of the system. The subject who rests without justification is 'lazy.'

The options the subject loses are concrete. The subject who needs rest loses the option to rest without producing a reason, which is to say, loses the option to bodily autonomy. The subject who is tired loses the option to rest, because tiredness is not a recognised justification. The subject who needs a sabbatical loses the option to leave, because sabbaticals are reserved for the senior.

The witness is the person who watches the justified rest enforcement and says nothing, or who themselves justify their rest and so model compliance. The witness's complicity is the shared acceptance that rest must be earned.

3.6 Extraction Triad: Wage-Labour Surplus

The extractor is the employer who pays the worker less than the value of what the worker produces. The factory owner. The bank. The multinational. The startup. The household that employs a domestic worker. The extraction is performed by the wage relation itself — the worker is paid less than the value of their labour.

The subject conforms by working. What is extracted is the surplus value — the difference between what the worker produces and what the worker receives. The extraction is invisible to the worker because the wage appears as fair exchange. The worker does not see the surplus because the surplus is realised by the owner after the worker has gone home.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The factory worker who produces goods worth 50,000 naira a day and is paid 5,000 naira loses the option to the products of their own labour. The domestic worker who cleans the house for 20,000 naira a month loses the option to a wage that would let them

clean their own house. The graduate who earns 150,000 naira at a multinational that bills their labour at 1.5 million loses the option to economic independence.

The witness is the person who watches the surplus extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves employ workers. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the consumer who buys the product at a price that reflects the owner's profit margin but does not personally command the wage extraction.

3.7 Extraction Triad: Attention

The extractor is the institution that requires the subject's cognitive attention. The employer who demands the worker's full attention. The platform that demands the user's scrolling attention. The school that demands the student's sitting attention. The church that demands the congregant's praying attention. The extraction is performed by the demand itself, by the design of the attention-capturing environment, or by punishing inattention.

The subject conforms by attending. What is extracted is the attention itself — the finite cognitive resource the subject directs at the productive task. The attention is the proof of the system. The subject who does not attend is 'distracted.'

The options the subject loses are concrete. The worker who gives full attention to the task loses the option to attention for their own life, which is to say, loses the option to a self outside work. The student who gives full attention to the lecture loses the option to think their own thoughts. The user who gives full attention to the scroll loses the option to a mind that is not fragmented.

The witness is the person who watches the attention extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves give attention. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the employer whose business grows because the worker's attention was extracted, without personally commanding the attention.

3.8 Extraction Triad: Reproductive Labour

The extractor is the system that requires the unpaid physical and emotional work of maintaining the worker. The husband who expects the wife to cook, clean, and care for the children so he can return to wage labour. The mother who expects the daughter to manage the household so the men can work. The state that expects the family to provide healthcare, education, and welfare so the state does not have to. The extraction is performed by expectation, by direct demand, or by punishing refusal.

The subject conforms by performing. What is extracted is the reproductive labour — the cooking, cleaning, childcare, eldercare, emotional management, household coordination. The labour is real. It is the same labour performed in paid domestic work, except the wife, daughter, or mother is not paid and cannot leave. Federici's wages-for-housework campaign showed that this labour is extracted from women to subsidise the wage-labour system.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The wife who performs reproductive labour loses the option to a career of her own, which is to say, loses the option to economic independence. The daughter who manages the household loses the option to her own childhood. The mother who provides

unpaid welfare loses the option to retirement.

The witness is the person who watches the reproductive labour extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves performed the same labour. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the husband whose wage labour is subsidised by the wife's unpaid labour, the father whose career is enabled by the daughter's household management — without personally commanding the labour.

3.9 Extraction Triad: Emotional Labour

The extractor is the institution that requires the subject's affective performance. The employer who demands the customer-service smile. The husband who demands the wife's soothing of his stress. The parent who demands the child's cheerful compliance. The pastor who demands the congregant's joyful worship. The extraction is performed by direct demand, by social pressure, or by punishing emotional non-performance.

The subject conforms by performing. What is extracted is the emotional labour — the smile, the patience, the enthusiasm, the compassion, performed regardless of the subject's actual feelings. The labour is invisible because it is performed as 'being nice.' The labour is exhausting because it requires the subject to split themselves from their own emotions.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The worker who performs emotional labour loses the option to their own emotional life, which is to say, becomes a kind of emotional servant. The wife who manages her husband's emotions loses the option to her own emotional life. The child who performs cheerful compliance loses the option to authentic feeling.

The witness is the person who watches the emotional labour extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves perform the same labour. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the customer who receives the smile, the husband who receives the soothing, the parent who receives the compliance — without personally commanding the labour.

3.10 Extraction Triad: Cognitive Labour

The extractor is the institution that requires the subject's immaterial labour — thinking, planning, designing, coordinating. The employer who demands the worker's creative problem-solving. The client who demands the consultant's strategic thinking. The platform that demands the user's content generation. The school that demands the student's critical thinking. The extraction is performed by the demand itself, by the design of the cognitive environment, or by punishing cognitive non-performance.

The subject conforms by thinking. What is extracted is the cognitive labour — the mental work that Lazzarato called 'immaterial labour' and Hardt and Negri called 'biopolitical production.' The cognitive worker brings their whole mind to work, and the boundary between work and life dissolves. The subject's mind has been annexed.

The options the subject loses are concrete. The worker who performs cognitive labour loses the option to a mind of their own, which is to say, loses the option to think their own thoughts. The creative who is required to produce on demand loses the option to inspiration. The student who is required to perform critical thinking loses the option to a mind that is not being measured.

The witness is the person who watches the cognitive labour extraction and does not intervene, or who themselves perform the same labour. The Non-Extracting Beneficiary is the employer whose business grows because the worker's cognitive labour was extracted, without personally commanding the labour.

Nascent forms of this system include: 'Get a job', 'What do you do?', 'You're lazy', 'You're wasting your life', 'Idle hands are the devil's workshop', 'Hard work pays', 'Hustle', 'Grind', 'No excuses', 'Rise and grind', 'Side hustle', 'Multiple streams of income', 'Don't waste time', 'Time is money', 'Money never sleeps', 'While you were sleeping', 'Early bird gets the worm', 'Burn the midnight oil', 'Work hard play hard', 'Sleep is for the weak', 'I'll sleep when I'm dead', 'I don't have time', 'I'm too busy', 'I'm slammed', 'Let's do lunch', 'You sleep too much', 'What have you achieved?', 'What have you done with your life?', 'You need to be productive', 'Be useful', 'Contribute to society', 'Pull your weight', 'Do your part', 'The youth are lazy', 'This generation doesn't want to work', 'Back in my day we worked harder', Judging the unemployed, Judging the retired, Judging the disabled who cannot work, Judging the creative who isn't monetising, Judging the parent who isn't earning, Judging the house-husband, Judging the student who isn't interning, Judging the worker who leaves at 5pm, Judging the worker who takes lunch, Judging the worker who takes leave.

SECTION 3 · NAIVE APPROACH

3. The Disciplinary Domain

When the ten triads above link into networks, Productivism scales. The link can be hierarchical (the enforcer at one level is the subject at the level above) or community-based (the witness at one triad becomes the enforcer at another). Both forms are visible in every Nigerian institution that organises work.

4.1 Disciplinary Hierarchy — Nested Stars

A Disciplinary Hierarchy is a chain of nested triads. The enforcer at one level is the subject at the level above. Each middle position is simultaneously subject above and enforcer below. Productivism spreads through this form in every Nigerian institution with a productivity-based chain of command.

Peak Triad-Node

At the peak is the triad where the highest productivity authority in the hierarchy enforces on the layer below. The peak enforcer is almost always the highest-ranking employer or supervisor, because Productivism ranks the productivity-enforcer at the top. The peak extracts wage-labour surplus, time, attention, reproductive labour, emotional labour, and cognitive labour from the layer below, and enforces the employment relationship, time standard, 9-to-5 schedule, CV/LinkedIn standard, and justified rest standard on everyone.

In the civil service, the peak triad is the Head of Service enforcing on Permanent Secretaries. In the multinational corporate, the peak is the Country Manager enforcing on Directors. In the bank, the peak is the Managing Director enforcing on Executive Directors. In the megachurch as productivist institution, the peak is the General Overseer enforcing on Pastors, with the ‘work for the Lord’ framing converting productivity into piety. In the family compound, the peak is the Patriarch enforcing on wives, sons, and daughters.

Middle Triad-Nodes

The middle nodes are where the chain’s character is clearest. Each middle enforcer is simultaneously subject above and enforcer below. The Director who kneels for the Country Manager in the morning demands kneeling from the Manager in the afternoon. The Senior Pastor who defers to the General Overseer at the altar demands deference from the Workers at the meeting.

The middle is where Productivism reproduces. The subject of today is the enforcer of tomorrow — as a manager, a senior pastor, a senior civil servant, a senior lecturer. The middle position teaches the subject to want the position above, which means learning to enforce on those below. By the time the worker becomes a manager, they have been disciplined by Productivism for two decades.

In the bank, the middle nodes run from Managing Director down through Executive Director, General Manager, Branch Manager, Operations Manager, Customer Service Officer, Cashier, and Security

Guard — with the IT Student and NYSC Corps Member at the bottom. Each layer enforces the employment relationship, time standard, 9-to-5 schedule, CV/LinkedIn standard, and justified rest standard on the layer below, and is in turn enforced on by the layer above.

Bottom Triad-Node

At the bottom is the triad where the lowest-ranked productivity enforcer enforces on the most vulnerable subject. The Operations Manager enforcing on the Cashier. The Branch Manager enforcing on the IT Student. The Lecturer enforcing on the Graduate Assistant. The Senior Student enforcing on the Junior Student. The Mother enforcing on the Daughter. The bottom is where the system's violence is most concentrated.

The bottom node is also where the hierarchy meets the community form. The Cashier who is enforced on by the Operations Manager is simultaneously the enforcer in the church Workers' meeting, where they enforce Productivism on the new Member. The intersection of hierarchy and community is what makes Productivism inescapable — the subject is enforced on at work and enforces in church, at home, in the WhatsApp group.

4.2 Disciplinary Community — Distributed Network

A Disciplinary Community is a distributed network. There is no peak, no chain of command. There is only circulation. The witness of one Productivism triad becomes the enforcer, subject, or witness of another. Productivism spreads laterally through any person who has witnessed productivity enforcement without dissenting.

LinkedIn Networks

LinkedIn is the textbook Productivism community. The platform circulates the CV/LinkedIn enforcement triad across millions of users. The user who posts a promotion is congratulated by hundreds. The user who posts a layoff is pitied. The user who posts nothing is invisible. The platform's algorithm rewards productivity signals and punishes rest.

WhatsApp Hustle Groups

The WhatsApp hustle group circulates Productivism laterally. The group for the 'young entrepreneurs' shares productivity tips, success stories, and side-hustle opportunities. The member who shares their grind is congratulated. The member who shares their rest is questioned. The pattern circulates without any central command.

Twitter Tech-Bro Communities

The Twitter tech-bro community circulates a specifically intense form of Productivism. The community valorises the 80-hour week, the side hustle, the multiple income streams, the personal brand. The community shames the worker who admits to rest. The community shames the creative who is not monetising. The community reproduces the achievement-subject culture Han described.

Pentecostal Prosperity Gospel

The Pentecostal prosperity gospel is the most powerful Productivism community in Nigeria. The Sunday sermon equates wealth with divine favour and poverty with spiritual failure. The testimony time rewards the subject who narrates their productivity as blessing. The prayer request for employment is the most common request in any Nigerian Pentecostal service. The community reproduces Productivism as theology.

NYSC Platoon Community

The NYSC orientation camp is a three-week Productivism community. The platoon is the basic unit. The platoon officer enforces the 5am wake, the 10pm lights-out, the drilling, the marching, the ‘Otondo’ discipline. The Corps Member who does not perform is punished. The community circulates the time, attention, and physical-labour extraction triads across thousands of Corps Members in a single orientation cycle. The Corps Members who have absorbed the camp’s discipline then carry it to their Places of Primary Assignment, where they enforce it on the next batch.

The Family WhatsApp Group

The family WhatsApp group is the most intimate Productivism community. The aunt who asks ‘when are you getting a job?’ The uncle who asks ‘what are you doing now?’ The cousin who shares their promotion. The parent who forwards the job advert. The group circulates Productivism across the family network, with no central command issuing the demand. The pattern circulates by repeated witnessing.

The Alumni WhatsApp Group

The alumni WhatsApp group is the Productivism community extended beyond the family. The class of 2008 group shares promotions, job adverts, business launches, and subtle status updates. The member who is not visibly producing is invisible. The member who shares their rest is questioned. The group reproduces Productivism across the professional network.

SECTION 4 · NAIVE APPROACH

4. The Structural Domain

Run the Ship of Theseus test. When the people in the initial Productivism triads are dead and replaced, when the networks are disbanded and reform, what is consistent? What outlives both individuals and groups? What forces new individuals and groups to re-form into the same patterns — not because anyone instructs them to, but because the residue makes any other pattern costly or invisible?

Productivism leaves all three residues. It is one of the most total systems in the framework. Almost every Nigerian institution carries Bureaucracy, Stratification, and Classification from Productivism simultaneously.

5.1 Bureaucracy — Enduring Rules and Procedures

Productivism's bureaucracy is the codified employment and productivity structure. The Labour Act 1974 codifies the employment relationship, working hours, leave, and termination. The Pension Reform Act 2004 codifies the retirement system, tying old-age security to a lifetime of wage labour. The Employee Compensation Act 2010 codifies workplace injury compensation, assuming the workplace is the central site of bodily risk.

The Industrial Training Fund (ITF) Act 2011 codifies the requirement that employers contribute to the training of workers, formalising the self-improvement labour extraction triad as state policy. The NYSC Act 1993 codifies the compulsory one-year service that extracts labour from every graduate under thirty. The National Employment Policy codifies the state's commitment to 'job creation,' framing employment as the route to social inclusion.

The National Bureau of Statistics' employment surveys codify unemployment as a measurable category, treating the unemployed as a problem to be solved by more employment. The 40-hour work week codified in Nigerian labour law is the formal minimum of wage labour. The minimum wage codifies the floor of the wage relation. The workplace inspection regime codifies the state's supervision of working conditions. The employers' association and trade union bureaucracy codify the negotiation of productivity and pay.

The Industrial Arbitration Panel and the National Industrial Court codify the resolution of workplace disputes, framing them as technical rather than political. The original 1974 Act authors are dead or retired. The bureaucracy lives.

5.2 Stratification — Enduring Zero-Sum Rankings

Productivism's stratification is the daily experience of productivity rank in every institutional encounter. **Employed/unemployed** — the employed ranks above the unemployed in social standing,

in moral authority, in family respect. **Formal/informal** — the formal-sector worker ranks above the informal-sector worker in legal recognition, in pension access, in social standing.

Paid/unpaid — the paid worker ranks above the unpaid worker in economic recognition, in social standing, in self-worth. **Public/private sector** — the private-sector banker ranks above the public-sector civil servant in income, while the public-sector civil servant ranks above the private-sector worker in job security. **Senior/junior** — the senior worker ranks above the junior in decision-making, in pay, in social standing.

Executive/staff — the executive ranks above the staff in compensation, in authority, in social standing. **Blue collar/white collar** — the white-collar worker ranks above the blue-collar worker in social standing, in cultural capital, in access to formal institutions. **NYSC/graduate** — the NYSC Corps Member ranks above the unemployed graduate in social standing, because the Corps Member is at least performing productivity.

Retiree/active — the active worker ranks above the retiree in social standing, because the retiree is no longer producing. **Self-employed/employed** — the self-employed entrepreneur ranks above the employed worker in hustle culture, while the employed worker ranks above the self-employed in stability. The ranking is in the air; it does not need to be announced.

The Lagos office enforces stratification without anyone issuing an order. The MD has the corner office. The Directors have the offices with windows. The Managers have the cubicles. The Officers have the open plan. The Interns have the standing desks. The NYSC Corps Members have the floor. The seating is the rank. Challenging the seating is challenging the productivity order.

5.3 Classification — Enduring Categorical Divisions

Productivism's classification is the set of categorical names that organise every Nigerian into productivity categories. **Employed** and **unemployed** — the universal pair, with employed as the legitimate and unemployed as the deviant. **Productive** and **unproductive** — the moral pair, with productive as the virtuous and unproductive as the deficient.

Hardworking and **lazy** — the moral pair, with hardworking as the virtuous and lazy as the sinful. **Ambitious** and **unambitious** — the aspiration pair, with ambitious as the praised and unambitious as the pitied. **Professional** and **unprofessional** — the workplace pair, with professional as the competent and unprofessional as the lacking.

Qualified and **unqualified** — the credential pair, with qualified as the certified and unqualified as the uncertified. **Experienced** and **inexperienced** — the time pair, with experienced as the senior and inexperienced as the junior. **Dedicated** and **distracted** — the attention pair, with dedicated as the focused and distracted as the deficient.

Ambitious and **complacent** — the drive pair, with ambitious as the striver and complacent as the settler. **Career-driven** and **family-oriented** — the moral-judgment pair, with career-driven as the productive and family-oriented as the 'wasted potential.' The classification does the work before any

individual enforcer shows up. A person walking into a job interview is already classified; the interviewer may ask the candidate's employment history directly. A person walking into a family event is already classified; the aunt may ask 'what are you doing now?' before greeting. Classification is the most universal structural residue.

SECTION 5

5. The Hegemonic Domain: The Ascension Ritual

Is Productivism ascended? Yes on all three counts. It produces all three structural residues including Stratification (so Internalised Domination applies). It has working Canon and Practice mechanisms. The vast majority of Nigerians cannot imagine a society without wage labour, without the 9-to-5, without the CV, without the ‘what do you do?’ question — despite the fact that pre-colonial Nigerian work was calibrated to season and festival, and the fact that the current arrangement was installed by specific colonial and post-colonial legal instruments within living memory.

6.1 Canon — Rewriting History

Canon is the present belief that Productivism has always been so. The origination of the structural residues — the Labour Act 1974, the NYSC Act 1993, the Pension Reform Act 2004, the 40-hour week — has been forgotten. The average Nigerian now takes wage labour, the 9-to-5, and the ‘what do you do?’ question as natural, eternal, and without alternative.

What is forgotten? The 40-hour work week is a 20th-century invention, won by labour struggle, not a natural feature of work. The 8-hour day was won by the international labour movement in the late 19th and early 20th centuries, after centuries of longer working days. Pre-colonial Nigerian work was calibrated to season, harvest, and festival, not to the clock. The Yoruba farmer worked the land from dawn to noon, rested through the heat of the afternoon, and worked again in the cool of the evening. The Igbo market woman traded on Eke, Orie, Afo, and Nkwo days, with the four-day week structuring time.

Also forgotten: that ‘unemployment’ as a category did not exist before colonial capitalism imposed wage labour. The pre-colonial Nigerian subject was not ‘employed’ or ‘unemployed’; they were a farmer, a trader, a craftsperson, a warrior, a priest, a mother, a child — with productive roles that were not mediated by the wage. The colonial imposition of wage labour created unemployment as a category by creating employment as a category.

Also forgotten: that the NYSC was a 1973 post-civil-war integration programme, not an eternal feature of Nigerian life. That the Pentecostal prosperity gospel’s equation of wealth with divine favour is a 1970s import from American televangelism, not an indigenous theology. That the ‘hustle culture’ of 2010s Lagos tech and social media is a 2010s import from Silicon Valley, not an eternal Nigerian value. That the ‘LinkedIn’ professional identity is a 2000s import from American corporate culture, not a natural feature of self-presentation.

Internalised Domination

Canon produces Internalised Domination because Productivism produces Stratification. The employer's felt entitlement to the surplus of labour and to the worker's time is now natural, automatic, unquestionable. The employer who expects the worker to answer emails at 10pm does not experience this as a demand. They experience it as the natural order of professional life.

The senior's entitlement to the junior's deference as productive subject is natural. The Director who expects the Manager to wait for the meeting does not feel they are enforcing. They feel they are being accorded their due. The working subject's entitlement to judge the non-working subject is natural. The employed person who says 'I work hard for my money' to dismiss the unemployed does not feel they are dominating. They feel they are stating fact.

The entitlement grows with repetition. The first time the worker did not answer the 10pm email, the employer felt surprise. The hundredth time, the employer feels outrage. The entitlement has been internalised so deeply that its non-fulfilment registers as injury. Byung-Chul Han calls this the 'achievement subject' — the subject who has internalised the demand to achieve so thoroughly that they no longer need an external enforcer.

Internalised Authority

Canon produces Internalised Authority in the productivity enforcer regardless of personal material gain. The parent who demands the adult child 'get a job' gains nothing material from the demand. The elder who demands the younger relative 'be useful' gains nothing material. The state that conscripts the young into NYSC gains nothing material from each individual conscript. The employer who demands the worker's attention at all hours gains nothing material from each individual email answer.

The aunt who asks 'when are you getting a job?' gains nothing material. The uncle who asks 'what have you achieved?' gains nothing material. The LinkedIn connection who judges the profile gains nothing material. The pastor who preaches against 'laziness' gains nothing material. Each is exercising internalised authority — the felt right to enforce the productivity standard regardless of personal gain.

Internalised Oppression

Canon produces Internalised Oppression in the unemployed subject, the worker, the housewife, the creative. The unemployed subject is taught that they are worth nothing without employment. The worker is taught that they cannot rest. The housewife is taught that her labour is not real labour because it is unpaid. The creative is taught that they must monetise or fail. The teaching is silent; it is in the air.

The unemployed graduate who is told by a sibling 'just get any job' is being disciplined by Canon. The worker who is told by a colleague 'you cannot leave at 5' is being disciplined by Canon. The housewife who is told by her mother 'you are not working' is being disciplined by Canon. Each internalises the impossibility of refusal.

The deepest form of this is the subject who has absorbed Productivism so thoroughly that they enforce it on themselves. The unemployed graduate who says 'I am useless' to explain why they cannot rest. The worker who says 'I should be grateful I have a job' to explain why they accept the 60-hour week.

The housewife who says ‘I am just a housewife’ to explain why she has no identity. The creative who says ‘I should monetise’ to explain why they cannot paint without selling. The rebellion-capable subject has become the self-policing subject.

6.2 Practice — Rewriting Reality

Practice is the second mechanism of the Ascension Ritual. The interpersonal triad is repeated, again and again, until it becomes habit. The productivity enforcer forgets they can choose not to enforce. The productivity subject forgets they can rebel. The productivity witness forgets they can dissent. The middle-aged parent who has been both subject and enforcer forgets they were ever either.

Pierre Bourdieu called this *habitus* — the sediment of repeated practice in the body. Byung-Chul Han, in *The Burnout Society* (2010), extended the analysis to the achievement subject: the worker who has internalised the demand to achieve so thoroughly that they no longer need an external enforcer.

Jonathan Crary, in *24/7* (2013), showed how the 24/7 market has colonised sleep, rest, and the night. The body learns. The mind stops questioning.

By the time the Nigerian child is twelve, the alarm clock is reflex. They know the 6am wake. They know the rush to school. They know the homework that takes the evening. They know the weekend lesson. By adulthood, the subject has performed the 9-to-5, the commute, the CV, the LinkedIn, the ‘what do you do?’ answer, the Saturday catch-up work, the Sunday planning for Monday so many thousands of times that the alternative — refusing the alarm, leaving the commute, dropping the CV — feels like a kind of amputation. The body has been trained. Practice has rewritten reality.

Death — Fast and Slow

Practice produces Death. Fast death in Productivism is spectacular: the worker suicide from overwork. The Japanese *karoshi* has Nigerian equivalents — the young banker who collapsed in Lagos in 2013 after a 72-hour shift; the NYSC Corps Member who died at orientation camp from exhaustion and heat in 2016; the market woman who died at her stall in Onitsha in 2019; the worker killed in the Lagos commute — the BRT bus accident, the okara fall, the third-mainland bridge crash.

The worker killed by workplace hazard — the factory worker crushed by the machine, the construction worker fallen from the scaffold, the oil worker killed in the refinery explosion. The graduate who died by suicide after years of unemployment — the 2018 case of the First Class graduate who could not find work and took his own life. The NYSC Corps Member who died at the Place of Primary Assignment because the camp clinic was inadequate.

Slow death in Productivism is quiet. Chronic stress from constant productivity demands — the worker who has not slept eight hours in twenty years because the 9-to-5 is the 9-to-9. Burnout as a medical diagnosis — the World Health Organisation recognised burnout as an occupational phenomenon in 2019, after decades of the condition being dismissed as personal weakness.

Mental health collapse from the 24/7 always-on culture — the worker who cannot stop checking emails, the entrepreneur who cannot stop strategising, the creative who cannot stop producing. The

worker whose body breaks down at 35 from years of overwork — the Lagos banker who is hypertensive at 30, the Abuja civil servant who is diabetic at 35, the Port Harcourt oil worker who has chronic back pain at 40. The Lagos traffic that grinds the commuter's spine — the four-hour daily commute that produces chronic musculoskeletal disorders across the workforce.

The eye strain from 14-hour screen days — the tech worker whose vision is failing at 28. The loss of friendships because there is no time to maintain them. The loss of family life because there is no time to be present. The loss of self because there is no time to know oneself. The unemployed subject whose mental health collapses from the chronic shame of non-production. The housewife whose body breaks down from years of unpaid reproductive labour with no recognition. None of these make the news. They are Productivism's quiet tax.

Ruth Wilson Gilmore's definition applies: Productivism produces group-differentiated vulnerability to premature death. The groups are the unemployed, the overworked, the housewife, the casual worker, the NYSC Corps Member, the gig worker, the retiree without a pension. The premature death is fast (overwork suicide, camp death, commute death, workplace hazard) or slow (stress, burnout, mental health collapse, body breakdown, chronic illness from overwork). Every ascended matrix kills. Productivism kills those whose relationship to productivity does not fit the wage-labour model.

SECTION 6

6. When Did Productivism Rewrite History?

The framework's historical question: when did Productivism rewrite history in popular Nigerian living memory, such that the average Nigerian cannot recall a time when its structural residue was not present? This is not a history of how Productivism was built. It is a diagnosis of when the building was forgotten.

Pre-colonial Nigerian work was calibrated to season, harvest, and festival, not to the clock. The Yoruba farmer worked the land from dawn to noon, rested through the heat, and worked again in the cool of the evening. The Igbo market woman traded on Eke, Orie, Afo, and Nkwo days, with the four-day week structuring time. The Hausa farmer worked the wet season intensively and the dry season lightly. The Tiv farmer worked the yam cycle. Work was not absent; it was differently organised. The wage was not the route to subsistence; subsistence was the route to subsistence.

Colonial codification (1900-1960) imposed wage labour as the route to subsistence. The colonial mining and agricultural industries required wage labour. The colonial railways, ports, and administration required wage labour. The colonial tax (the hut tax, the poll tax) was payable in colonial currency, which could only be earned in wage labour. The colonial school trained the subject for clerical wage labour. Unemployment as a category was created by the imposition of employment as a category.

Post-independence replication continued the displacement. The NYSC was created in 1973 as a post-civil-war integration programme, conscripting every graduate into one year of compulsory service. The Labour Act 1974 codified the employment relationship on the colonial model. The Structural Adjustment Programme (SAP) of 1986 intensified Productivism by imposing structural adjustment productivity — the formal sector shrank, the informal sector expanded, the wage fell, and the worker had to work more to earn the same.

The pension reform of 2004 tied old-age security to a lifetime of formal wage labour. The telecoms and banking expansions of the 2000s and 2010s created the high-productivity professional culture of Lagos. The Pentecostal prosperity gospel of the 1980s onward supplied Canon for Productivism by equating wealth with divine favour. The Silicon Valley hustle culture of the 2010s imported the 24/7 achievement-subject model into Lagos tech, social media, and finance.

The tipping point in popular living memory: **circa 1973 for NYSC and the post-civil-war reconstruction productivism; circa 1986 for SAP and the imposition of structural adjustment productivity; circa 2010s for hustle culture and the tech-bro productivism.** For Nigerians born after 1960 — the post-independence generation — Productivism has 'always been' in its current form. They cannot recall a time when wage labour was not the route to subsistence, when the 9-to-5 was not the shape of the day, when the 'what do you do?' question was not the introductory question.

The pre-productivist generation (born ~1930s-1940s) was the last to have living memory of seasonal, festival-calibrated work outside the wage relationship. By the 1990s, the SAP-induced intensification of Productivism had become the natural order. By the 2010s, the hustle culture had become the natural order. The question ‘is wage labour natural?’ had stopped being asked in popular memory by the 1980s. The question ‘is the 9-to-5 natural?’ stopped being asked by the 1990s. The question ‘is the hustle natural?’ stopped being asked by the 2010s.

SECTION 7

7. Fill in the Blank: A Self-Examination

The framework asks two questions of every subject of every ascended matrix. The blanks are for you. They are not rhetorical. The point of the framework is not to understand Productivism in the abstract. It is to locate yourself inside it, so that the next time the triad assembles around you — or around someone whose relationship to productivity does not fit the wage-labour model — you can see it.

Question 1: When did Productivism rewrite your reality?

When did the system teach you that you could not rebel? The moment was: _____. The year was: _____. The person who first made you feel that challenging the demand to produce was impossible was: _____. The place was: _____. What you wanted to say but did not was: _____. What you did instead was: _____. What you told yourself about why you did not say it was: _____. The productivity performance you assumed in that moment was: _____. The form of address you used was: _____. What you lost, in that moment, that you have not got back since, was: _____. The form of work or productivity at the centre of the moment was: _____.

Question 2: How is Productivism causing your Death?

How is the system shortening your life right now? The form of Death I am most afraid of from Productivism is (fast/slow): _____. The specific way it is happening in my body is: _____. (For example: the chronic stress from years of 60-hour weeks; the insomnia from years of checking emails at 11pm; the loss of self from years of being told my worth is my productivity; the breakdown I had in 20__ that I have never fully recovered from; the relationship I lost because I could not stop working; the medical diagnosis I now live with because the stress had nowhere else to go; the family event I missed because I was at the office; the friend I lost because I had no time to maintain the friendship; the creative work I never made because I was always producing for someone else.) The matrix’s name for what is happening to me is: _____. My own name for it is: _____.

If you filled in the blanks honestly, you have just located yourself inside Productivism. The next time the triad assembles — the next time the alarm rings, the next time the boss demands, the next time the ‘what do you do?’ question is asked — you will be able to see the system moving through you. That sight is the beginning of abolition. And if you are now the enforcer in the triad — the employer, the supervisor, the parent demanding the adult child ‘get a job’ — the sight is also the beginning of your refusal to enforce.

SECTION 8

8. Endnotes & References

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Coming Next

Chapter 9 will take up Invasion — the system by which a foreign power invades a locale to extract something tangible and enforce its standards on the locals. The framework's outline names neoliberalism (IMF/World Bank), dollar hegemony, Saudi/Wahhabist religious invasion, American evangelical Christianity, Silicon Valley tech invasion, and Chinese economic invasion as contemporary instances. Invasion overlaps with Enclosure (Chapter 7) at the extraction of resources and with Religious Dominance (Chapter 6) at the religious-invasion cases. The framework separates them so that the foreign-power logic specifically can be studied and dismantled.

If you are reading this chapter as part of the framework in progress, the order continues: Chapter 10 is Settler Colonialism, Chapter 11 is Coloniality, Chapter 12 is Somatic Normativity, and so on through the Fundamental Matrices. Each chapter follows the same template established in Chapters 2 through 8. The naive approach in the first three domains. The Ascension Ritual in the fourth. The historical

memory trace. The fill-in-the-blank. The endnotes. The pattern is now set.